



N.E.S.T

NURTURING EDUCATION WITH SCHOOL & THERAPY

Signs to Look For Before Age 3

A Parent's Early Development Checklist

12 MO

18 MO

2 YRS

2.5-3 YRS

- A free guide from N.E.S.T Special Education & Therapy Center
DHA Phase 2, Sector G, Islamabad

Before You Begin

Every child grows at their own pace, and a little variation from one milestone chart to the next is completely normal. But research is clear on one thing: the earlier a developmental difference is noticed, the more options parents have, and the better children tend to respond to support.

This checklist isn't a diagnostic tool and it isn't meant to worry you. It's meant to help you notice patterns, trust your instincts, and know when a professional opinion is worth getting. If you're raising a child in Islamabad or DHA and something on this list feels familiar, you're not alone, and help is closer than you think.

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Age bands covered

3

Development areas: speech,
social, behavior

2-20

Ages N.E.S.T supports

A quick note before we start

This guide touches on signs linked to speech and language delay, autism spectrum differences, ADHD, and general developmental delay. One or two items alone rarely mean much. A pattern across several areas, or a skill that's clearly regressing, is what's worth paying attention to.

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By 12 Months

- Doesn't respond to their name being called
- No babbling (like "ba-ba" or "da-da") by 9-12 months
- Doesn't point, wave bye-bye, or reach to be picked up
- Little to no eye contact during feeding or play
- Doesn't react to loud sounds or seem to notice familiar voices

TYPICAL AT THIS AGE

At this age, babies typically respond to their name, babble back and forth, and enjoy simple games like peekaboo with a caregiver.

- Says fewer than 6-10 words
- Doesn't point to show you something interesting ("look at that!")
- Doesn't imitate sounds, gestures, or simple actions (clapping, blowing a kiss)
- Seems unaware of other children or uninterested in shared play
- Unusually intense reactions to routine changes, textures, sounds, or lights

TYPICAL AT THIS AGE

By 18 months, most toddlers point to show interest, copy simple actions, and are building a small but growing vocabulary.

- No two-word phrases ("more juice," "mama up")
- Vocabulary isn't growing — stuck at the same handful of words for months
- Doesn't follow simple one-step instructions ("bring me the ball")
- Limited pretend play (not feeding a doll, not "talking" on a toy phone)
- Extreme difficulty with transitions, or very limited range of interests/play

TYPICAL AT THIS AGE

Around age 2, most children combine two words, follow simple instructions, and enjoy pretend play like feeding a toy.

- Speech is hard for even family members to understand
- Doesn't combine words into short sentences
- Doesn't ask simple questions or engage in back-and-forth conversation
- Very high activity level, impulsivity, or inability to sit for even short routines
- Loses words or skills they previously had (especially worth a conversation with your pediatrician)

TYPICAL AT THIS AGE

By 2.5-3 years, most children speak in short sentences that familiar adults can mostly understand, and can hold a brief back-and-forth exchange.

What to Do If You Notice These Signs

Take a breath first. Noticing early is a good thing, not a crisis.

- **Start with your pediatrician.** Mention specifically what you've observed — they can rule out hearing issues or refer you onward.
- **Ask for a developmental or speech-language screening.** These are low-risk, non-invasive, and often take less than an hour.
- **Don't wait for “maybe it'll resolve itself.”** Early intervention has the strongest evidence behind it of anything we do in this field.
- **Trust yourself.** You spend more time with your child than any clinician ever will.

How N.E.S.T Can Help

We work with children ages 2 to 20 across autism, ADHD, Down syndrome, speech and language delays, and other developmental needs, right here in DHA Phase 2, Islamabad. Our assessment process is warm and unhurried — we spend real time observing your child, talking with you about what you've noticed at home, and building a picture together before anyone uses a label.

Book an assessment: nestislamabad.com